IN SEPTEMBER, RATNA Singh, 28, travelled from Ludhiana to Delhi for her wedding shopping. The destination: DLF Emporio, which was hosting its annual Treasury of Trousseau event that brings together couture, jewellery, gifting and styling services for brides, grooms and their families.

Singh was not alone. Eleven other families from Ludhiana, also on a weekend visit to DLF Emporio, were picked up from the airport and checked into partner hotels, through private operators who had also flown in similar groups from Indore and Chandigarh.

In order to ensure guests did not feel overwhelmed with the vast elite catalog, DLF matched them with experts even before they arrived; guests registered their shopping interests and booked personalised consultations with stylists, designers, beauty consultants, etc. The edition featured collection launches, designer interactions and presentations by names such as Tarun Tahiliani, Gaurav Gupta, and Arpita Mehta. For those unable to visit, DLF offered personal-shopping consultations by video call and WhatsApp.

These services reflect a market shift: luxury retailers increasingly serving customers whose wealth and homes are located well beyond the metros.

"Luxury demand is no longer necessarily proportional to the size of a city," says Pushpa Bector, Group Executive Director and Business Head, DLF Retail, which operates luxury malls DLF Emporio and The Chanakya in New Delhi. "Industry data has highlighted that approximately 35% of DLF Emporio's sales are accounted for by customers from outside Delhi," she says. She identifies Chandigarh, Lucknow, Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Surat and Indore among the relevant markets. "Rising incomes, entrepreneurship, wealth creation, international exposure and a younger, digitally connected consumer base are driving luxury in emerging cities. Luxury is increasingly viewed not only as a marker of status but also an expression of personal achievement and style," she says.

Bector says emerging-city consumers engage with luxury more around weddings, festivals and milestone celebrations while metro consumers tend to have more frequent, lifestyle-led interactions across categories. "We are seeing the emergence of a more aspirational but informed consumer. They may be entering luxury through accessories, beauty, watches or contemporary fashion before progressing towards couture, fine jewellery and more high-value purchases," says Bector. "The opportunity, however, lies not just in replicating metro formats. It is about understanding consumer profile, spending behaviour and aspirations, and creating the right combination of brands and experiences," she says.

The trend is the result of a growing number of millionaire households beyond metros. India had 871,700 dollar millionaire households in 2025, a 90% increase from 458,000 in 2021, according to the Mercedes-Benz Hurun India Wealth Report. Mumbai had 142,000 such households followed by New Delhi (68,200) and Bengaluru (31,600). The other cities are also making a mark. Ahmedabad had 26,800 millionaire households, Surat 5,700, Jaipur 4,800, Vadodara 4,600, Nagpur 3,700, and Lucknow and Visakhapatnam 2,900 each.

GOING ONLINE

Online channels are making it easier for customers beyond the metros to access luxury goods. At Tata CLiQ Luxury, approximately 56% of gross merchandise value in FY27 to date has come from markets the platform classifies as non-metro, according to Chief Executive Gopal Asthana. Markets with strong demand include Chandigarh, Surat, Lucknow, Jaipur, Indore, Nagpur and Guwahati. "We have seen consumers from smaller towns such as Godhra, Bhondsi, Chorasi, Bareilly and Katni purchase watches," says Asthana.

THE NEW LUXURY MAP

- 35% OF DLF EMPORIO SALES COME FROM CUSTOMERS OUTSIDE DELHI
- 56% OF TATA CLIQ LUXURY'S GMV COMES FROM NON-METRO MARKETS ACROSS TIER I–IV CITIES
- AMONG FIRST-TIME BUYERS IN TIER-II AND TIER-III MARKETS, WATCHES LEAD BY SALES VALUE, WHILE FOOTWEAR GENERATES VOLUMES
- MERCEDES-BENZ IS ADDING TOUCHPOINTS TO EMERGING CITIES, AND THE COLLECTIVE IS OPENING STORES IN LUDHIANA AND PATIALA